

When AI Assistance Becomes the Workflow

Knowledge Work, Professional Judgment, and Cognitive Drift

Cognitive Drift Papers — Mechanism Brief #1

A. Jacobs

Core Pattern

individual expertise → digital augmentation → AI assistance → workflow dependence → Cognitive Drift

Knowledge work increasingly happens through representations.

Professionals interpret documents, analyze data, write reports, coordinate teams, build strategies, and make decisions through systems that stand between them and the realities they are trying to understand.

AI enters this environment as more than another productivity tool.

It drafts, summarizes, retrieves, compares, organizes, and maintains context across entire projects. As it becomes embedded throughout the workflow, professional reasoning begins to develop through interaction with AI-generated representations rather than through isolated acts of individual judgment.

What Is Actually Changing

Traditional workplace software supported tasks.

Word processors stored text.

Spreadsheets organized calculations.

Databases preserved records.

AI participates at a different level.

Professionals now begin projects with AI, develop ideas through AI, organize research with AI, revise writing through AI, and preserve working context through AI.

The tool no longer appears only at the edge of the process.

It becomes part of the process itself.

Human judgment remains essential.

But more of the intermediate reasoning is now externalized into systems that generate and transform representations before the professional evaluates them.

The Hidden Mechanism

AI assistance can improve output while reducing visibility into how the output was formed.

A meeting becomes a transcript.

The transcript becomes a summary.

The summary becomes a plan.

The plan becomes a presentation.

The presentation becomes a decision.

At each stage, meaning is compressed and reorganized.

The final artifact may be coherent, useful, and professionally polished while preserving only part of the uncertainty, disagreement, and context that shaped the original situation.

The work still looks strong.

The reasoning chain becomes harder to inspect.

Cognitive Drift

Cognitive Drift occurs when professional work remains productive while the relationship between judgment and the systems shaping that judgment becomes less visible.

The problem is not simple automation.

It is the gradual transfer of framing, comparison, synthesis, and continuity into external systems.

A professional may still approve the final decision while becoming less able to reconstruct how assumptions changed, which alternatives disappeared, or where the reasoning began to move in a different direction.

Semantic Fidelity

Semantic Fidelity asks whether important relationships, evidence, intentions, and constraints survive as work moves across documents, meetings, prompts, generated summaries, and organizational decisions.

A summary may accurately describe a meeting while omitting the uncertainty that mattered most.

A proposal may remain persuasive while subtly changing the team's original priorities.

An analysis may appear comprehensive while compressing away distinctions that remain professionally important.

Efficiency does not guarantee fidelity.

Professional polish does not guarantee contact with the original problem.

Reality Drift Interpretation

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, AI-assisted knowledge work is a distributed representational system.

Its value comes from extending memory, accelerating synthesis, and reducing the effort required to coordinate complex work.

Its risk appears when professionals increasingly respond to representations generated inside the workflow rather than to the underlying conditions those representations were meant to clarify.

Reality Drift begins when the organization continues producing coherent decisions while becoming less able to trace those decisions back to evidence, experience, and accountable judgment.

Recognition Questions

- Can the reasoning behind the final output still be reconstructed?
- Which parts of the workflow now depend on AI-generated interpretation?
- Did the system preserve uncertainty or convert it into confidence?
- Are professionals evaluating the reasoning or mainly reviewing the artifact?
- Which assumptions changed between the original material and the final decision?
- What direct contact with the underlying situation remains?

Core Principle

AI assistance becomes the workflow when external systems participate continuously in framing, organizing, and revising professional thought.

Cognitive Drift begins when output quality remains high while visibility into the reasoning process declines.

The future of knowledge work depends not only on producing better artifacts, but on preserving Semantic Fidelity across the systems through which professional judgment now develops.